

Jeffrey P. Punske, *Morphology: A Distributed Morphology Introduction*, First Edition. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley-Blackwell, 2024. xv + 288 pp. ISBN 978-1-119-66783-4 (paperback).

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Within mainstream generative linguistics, many scholars have converged around the idea that morphology *is*, or at least substantively *begins with*, syntax. Foremost among approaches that pursue this idea is Distributed Morphology (DM), an umbrella label covering a set of closely related proposals that share a number of theoretical tenets, most centrally: (i) syntax first (or, syntax all-the-way-down): the basic combinatorial engine in the grammar is syntax, and the atoms of syntax are roots and functional elements, termed abstract morphemes, and (ii) late insertion: the abstract morphemes manipulated by syntax do not have phonological content—phonological exponents are instead inserted into syntactic terminal nodes post-syntactically, via a process called Vocabulary Insertion. Other common assumptions found in DM include: (i) roots lack an inherent syntactic category, (ii) functional morphemes (even when affixal) are integrated into regular phrasal syntax, and (iii) in addition to Vocabulary Insertion, there are other operations that take place after syntax, such as feature deletion (Impoverishment) and structural reorganization (e.g., Local Dislocation, Lowering). Putting this all together, DM takes the phenomena and operations that are traditionally associated with a dedicated morphological component (for some, the lexicon) and *distributes* them across the syntax and post-syntax. (See, *inter alia*, Noyer 1992, Halle and Marantz 1993, 1994, Halle 1997, Marantz 1997, Harley and Noyer 1999, Bobaljik 2000, 2012, 2017, Embick and Noyer 2001, Embick 2010, Arregi and Nevins 2012, Harley 2014, Harizanov and Gribanova 2019, Alexiadou et al. To appear.)

The textbook under review here, *Morphology: A Distributed Morphology Introduction* by Jeffrey Punske, is the *only* textbook out there that is specific to the framework of DM. Thus while there are some excellent introductory morphology textbooks already in circulation, this textbook fills a crucial gap, bridging the divide between the classroom and a mountain of contemporary linguistic scholarship. The textbook is aimed at being appropriate for an undergraduate level, requiring little background in morphology or other areas of linguistics, while also seeking to be appropriate as a capstone after students have taken coursework in other subfields. Accordingly, the textbook is split into two halves, with Part One providing a general introduction to morphological analysis and Part Two providing an introduction specifically to the framework of DM. The overarching stated goal of this textbook is “to provide an introduction into the core concepts of theoretical morphology, particularly from the perspective of Distributed Morphology” (p. xi), specifically emphasizing “ways of thinking in Distributed Morphology”, in order to enable students to “analyze novel morphological data” and “explore primary literature” (p. xii). Punske, the author, is well-qualified to write a textbook on DM. Punske is a long-time practitioner of DM, having published DM-based work on nominalizations, compounding, and verb particle constructions, among other topics at the morphology/syntax interface. Punske has also been involved in a variety of pedagogically directed work, in particular related to language invention (Punske et al. 2020) and gaming (McKenzie and Punske 2019) as tools in linguistics teaching.

Our overall assessment of this textbook, which is in its first edition, is that it has admirable goals, a number of strengths, and substantial potential, but that significant revision is needed for it to more effectively achieve its stated goals and reach its full potential. The textbook’s strengths include its utilization of a number of excellent pedagogical tools and its inclusion of a wide variety of phenomena, languages, and topics. However, issues that range from typographical to analytical make it challenging to use as-is as the primary textbook for an undergraduate morphology course, as we (the authors of this review) can attest firsthand. In this review, we first provide an overview of the contents of the textbook, within which we identify its key strengths, and we then discuss the different types of issues that may arise for students and instructors when using the textbook. Throughout, we highlight the information which we believe will be most helpful to instructors considering making use of this textbook in the classroom. Please note that we have not attempted to do the end-of-chapter exercises, and so will make no substantive comments on these, except to say that an answer key for these exercises would be a welcome resource for instructors. Also note that we reviewed only the paperback version of this textbook, and not the e-book; we are aware of further issues specific to the e-book which we do not address.

Beginning Part One of the textbook, Chapter One and Chapter Two present a solid entry point into the study of morphology, adopting a classic definition as “the study of the word” (p. 3). Chapter One situates morphology within generative grammar and the scientific study of language more generally, with an effective discussion of the scientific method and the role of Occam’s Razor. This chapter also includes a brief birds-eye view of the theoretical landscape, contrasting DM with lexicalist approaches to the study of morphology, where morphology is wholly separate from syntax. Punske helpfully situates DM in this landscape as a framework specifically aiming “to reduce complexity by eliminating the lexicon and the associated redundancy of operations in it” (p. 12). Chapter Two covers a number of concrete and fundamental morphological concepts, from a morpheme-based perspective. The reader is introduced to classic notions of affixation as well as a sampling of theoretically important phenomena, including clitics, reduplication, root-and-pattern morphology, and truncation. The chapter also gives a useful overview of what sorts of morphology commonly show up with words of different categories (e.g., tense and agreement with verbs), and the concept of a Greenbergian Universal is introduced as fodder for theoretical inquiry. Here and throughout, numerous exemplars of phenomena are provided and examples are glossed. We particularly appreciate the framing of glossing as a *hypothesis*, emphasizing for students that even what seem to be the basic facts of a language are themselves the result of analysis.

Chapter Three is a strong, pedagogically useful chapter, covering both where data come from and how to approach novel data. Punske discusses considerations in gathering linguistic data, including distinguishing between primary and secondary data collection, and between pedagogical and descriptive grammars. As teachers, we appreciate pausing analysis for a moment to have students home in on the origin of the data we linguists use, as well as its interrelated practical and ethical considerations. The chapter continues by slowly and carefully working through a few small data sets from Mam and Michif, providing crucial scaffolding for students doing this for the first time. An outstanding pedagogical tool utilized throughout this chapter, as well as the rest of the textbook, is the text boxes accompanying examples and diagrams. Text boxes are used to add helpful information, for example, pointing out an emerging generalization, highlighting a relevant subpart of an example, or explaining a specific aspect of a formalism. These text boxes make the linguistic and technical content much more approachable, and are invaluable to students and instructors.

Rounding out Part One of the textbook are Chapter Four and Chapter Five, both of which add crucial analytical tools to the student’s repertoire. In line with the textbook’s stated goal to be appropriate for students with little/no background in linguistics, Chapter Four undertakes the important task of covering the core aspects of phonology that are relevant for the analysis of morphological data, including the International Phonetic Alphabet (and all its cross-cutting dimensions), phonemes and allophones, syllable structure, phonological operations, rule-writing, and naturalness, as well as the more DM-specific morphophonological “readjustment” rule. Chapter Five then employs the tools of all the preceding chapters to do more advanced morphological analysis. This chapter features extended discussions of reduplication in Hiaki and Tawala as implicating an interplay of syllabification, markedness, assimilation, and dissimilation. We found the discussion of markedness particularly valuable, as this is something that implicitly or explicitly plays a role in many linguistic analyses, but is often neglected at the introductory level. The end of Chapter Five analyzes reduplicative infixation in Uradhi, Amis, and Pangasinan (n.b. misspelled as “Pangasian” in the textbook).

Chapter Six and Chapter Seven, the first chapters in Part Two of the textbook, are dedicated to the task of building up the framework of DM, and so it is fitting that they are the two longest chapters. In Chapter Six, features are thoroughly discussed as crucial building blocks of analyses in DM, along with the closely connected concepts of paradigms, realization, vocabulary items, the Subset Principle, and the elsewhere distribution. As the core exemplars all come from pronominal systems, the feature geometry of Harley and Ritter 2002 is introduced as well, though Punske converts the privative pronominal features to binary ones in his analyses. There are a number of helpful pedagogical walk-throughs in this chapter, in particular for Polish pronouns (pp. 113–116) and Yokuts pronouns (pp. 125–132), showing that complex morphological paradigms can be profitably broken down into primitive features, and from there, mapped to a form via Vocabulary Insertion. The Yokuts walk-through cleverly demonstrates to students how to fill in a paradigm separately for every posited exponent, as a way to draw out the patterns. Along the way, Punske motivates the post-syntactic DM operation Impoverishment for capturing the interaction of markedness and syncretisms, accounting for the fewer morphological contrasts found in marked contexts. Chapter Seven expands on these themes, situating DM within the Y model of grammar and relating it to earlier proposals tying morphology together with syntax, specifically, Baker’s Mirror Principle (Baker 1985). This chapter also

motivates and exemplifies more DM machinery piece-by-piece, including the syntactic operations of upward head-to-head movement and head lowering, and the post-syntactic operations of Fusion and Fission.

The remainder of the chapters in the textbook take up specific phenomena, and apply a DM approach to them; these chapters are all brief, the longest being 11 pages (including end-of-chapter material). Chapter Eight extends the decompositional reasoning of DM to semantic aspects of verb argument structure, discussing theta theory and syntactic Case, positing CAUSE and BECOME flavors of Voice as separate from a verb's core meaning, and exploring root entailments in the context of cognate objects of intransitives. Chapter Nine presents a decompositional approach to root-and-pattern morphology, first couched in a lexicalist approach, and then in DM. In Chapter Ten, compounding and noun incorporation are unified as structures involving head-to-head movement of roots into other root terminals. Chapter Eleven turns to the branch of the Y model that leads to Logical Form to discuss idiom and metaphor interpretation, which crucially (in the proposed model) involve the Encyclopedia, the repository of real-world knowledge. This chapter provides some fun classroom fodder, related to the idea that the amount of structure involved in an idiom correlates with the ability of the idiom to be syntactically manipulated. Closing out the textbook is Chapter Twelve, which most notably provides a complete and final derivational model of the grammar according to DM, including in this model many major concepts and terms introduced in the textbook.

In addition to the content of the chapters, there are a few other kinds of material found in the textbook. Supplementary to every chapter are (i) a glossary of relevant terms and concepts introduced in the chapter along with suggestions for further reading, and (ii) a large set of exercises, both basic and advanced, which introduce new data sets and invite students to think critically about the material. At the end of the whole textbook are consonant and vowel IPA charts, a language glossary listing all the languages discussed in the textbook and source(s) for the data/analyses, a glossary of terms (the summation of the chapter glossaries), and a general reference list.

As we mentioned at the outset of this review, despite the textbook's praise-worthy ambition, coverage, and certain pedagogical strengths, it also has a variety of issues in its current (first) edition, with the most serious problems concentrated in Part Two of the textbook. We group the issues we encountered into four types, starting with those that pose the greatest challenges in a classroom setting: (i) analytical issues: analyses that do not work as presented in the text, (ii) terminological issues: unclear, non-standard, and/or inconsistently used terminology, (iii) pedagogical issues: suboptimal or perfunctory exemplars for teaching key concepts, and (iv) typographical issues: typos and formatting mistakes. As we go, we address what we think are the most significant examples of these different kinds of issues, in the hopes that this level of detail can facilitate instructors' use of the textbook even in its current form.

First and foremost, the thorniest issue for an instructor comes from fine details of analyses that do not work as stated in the textbook. This arises, for example, in the analysis of reduplicative infixation in Chapter Five (pp. 95–98), which addresses related but distinct empirical patterns in three languages. The textbook's analysis provides no explanation for the *direction* of copying, needed to differentiate Amis, where a right edge reduplicative infix copies what precedes it, from Uradhi and Pangasinan, where a left edge reduplicative infix copies what follows it. Another example of analytical incompleteness is found in Chapter Seven in a discussion about the morphosyntactic breakdown of semantically non-compositional words. The words given for illustration are non-compositional *terrific* vs. (the more) compositional *horrific* (pp. 154–155). In the provided structures, these are both broken down into a root (*horror*, *terror*), a categorizing n head (null), and an adjectival suffix (*-ic*). Confusingly, there is no discussion of how/why these are not realized as the predicted **horroric*, **terroric*; the textbook simply states in the derivational diagrams that (unspecified) “phonological operations” give rise to the forms *horrific*, *terrific*.

The most significant example of an analytical issue, and one we'll accordingly spend significant space on in this review, comes from the extended discussion of Yokuts pronouns in Part Two of the textbook (pp. 125–132 in Chapter Six, and continued on pp. 162–166 in Chapter Seven). This example is central to the most important chapters of the textbook and is the single most extensively discussed data set in the whole textbook. The culminating analysis of Yokuts pronouns is intended to show the power of DM's decompositional, realizational, featural approach, specifically in combination with the post-syntactic tool of Fission. However, the textbook's analysis does not make the correct predictions for the forms of most of the pronouns, as we'll demonstrate here. The Yokuts nominative pronouns are shown in Table 1. As can be seen in the table, Yokuts makes a three-way number distinction—singular, dual, plural—and a four-way person distinction—first, second inclusive, second exclusive, and third (n.b. the inclusive is characterized as

Table 1: Yokuts nominative pronouns

	singular [+MINIMAL, -PLURAL]	dual [+MINIMAL, +PLURAL]	plural [-MINIMAL, +PLURAL]
1st [+PARTICIPANT, +AUTHOR, -ADDRESSEE]	naʔ (n-aʔ)	naʔakʔ (n-aʔ-akʔ)	naʔan (n-aʔ-an)
2nd inclusive [+PARTICIPANT, +AUTHOR, +ADDRESSEE]	—	makʔ (m-Ø-akʔ)	may (m-Ø-ay)
2nd exclusive [+PARTICIPANT, -AUTHOR, +ADDRESSEE]	maʔ (m-aʔ)	maʔakʔ (m-aʔ-akʔ)	maʔan (m-aʔ-an)
3rd [-PARTICIPANT]	ʔamaʔ (ʔam-aʔ)	ʔamakʔ (ʔam-akʔ)	ʔaman (ʔam-an)

second person due to the overlap in form between the inclusive pronouns and the exclusive second person pronouns). Table 1 includes the features defining each category (pp. 127-131), the surface pronominal forms (Harley and Ritter 2002), and, in parentheses, Punske’s proposed decompositions (p. 166).

The textbook’s analysis of Yokuts pronouns proceeds as follows. Structurally, the pronouns are proposed to consist of a PersonP which contains a NumberP. The Person head is post-syntactically doubled via a rule of Fission in the context of [+PARTICIPANT, +PLURAL], i.e., for non-singular first and second person pronouns (p. 165):

- (1) Before Fission: PersonP After Fission: PersonP
- ```

graph TD
 PersonP --> Person
 PersonP --> NumberP
 NumberP --> Number

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graph TD
 PersonP --> Person1[Person]
 PersonP --> NumberP
 Person1 --> Person2[Person]
 Person1 --> Person3[Person]
 NumberP --> Number

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As reflected in Table 1, due to Fission, the non-singular first and second person pronouns each consist of three exponents, corresponding to the three heads post-Fission; the other pronouns each consist of two exponents, one for Person, one for Number. Punske proposes the following vocabulary items for the pronouns (p. 166):

- (2) a. [ ] → -aʔ (elsewhere exponent)  
b. [+ADDRESSEE] → m-  
c. [+AUTHOR, +ADDRESSEE] → -Ø  
d. [+AUTHOR, -ADDRESSEE] → n-  
e. [-PARTICIPANT] → ʔam-  
f. [+MINIMAL, +PLURAL] → -akʔ  
g. [-MINIMAL, +PLURAL] → -an  
h. [-MINIMAL, +PLURAL] → -ay / [+AUTHOR, +ADDRESSEE]

A similar set of exponents to that in (2) works well for Chapter Six’s version of the Yokuts analysis, within which all the pronouns are taken to have three morphological “slots”, and only certain exponents compete with each other in each slot. However, in attempting to do away with slots, and to instead rely on the structures in (1) and free competition among vocabulary items, Vocabulary Insertion goes awry, specifically due to the duplication of the Person head. Given the Subset Principle, the more specific zero exponent, (2c), should preempt *m-*, (2b), in all [+AUTHOR, +ADDRESSEE] contexts. As a result, the zero exponent is predicted to appear in *both* Person heads in such pronouns, thereby incorrectly generating the form \*akʔ (from Ø-Ø-akʔ) for second person inclusive dual, and the form \*ay (from Ø-Ø-ay) for second person inclusive plural. Similarly due to the Subset Principle, the more specific *m-*, (2b), and *n-*, (2d), are predicted to preempt the featureless elsewhere exponent -aʔ, (2a), in [-AUTHOR, +ADDRESSEE] contexts and [+AUTHOR, -ADDRESSEE] contexts, respectively. This would incorrectly generate \*mmakʔ (from *m-m-akʔ*) for second person exclusive dual, \*mman (from *m-m-an*) for second person exclusive plural, \*nnakʔ (from *n-n-akʔ*) for first person dual, and \*nnan (from *n-n-an*) for first person plural. While we have not fully worked out an alternative analysis

to the one offered in the textbook, some aspect(s) of a slot-based analysis would essentially need to be replicated in the DM analysis, which in turn would undermine the pedagogical utility of this example.

A second type of issue found in the textbook is terminological: while most of the necessary terminology and abstract concepts are defined clearly and used consistently, there are several specific terminological issues that arise. We mention here those that are likely to be most confusing to students. An early terminological confusion is about the terms “base” and “stem”. In their first mention in the textbook (p. 21), these are defined and exemplified as the “base” referring to the innermost form with all affixes stripped off (usually the root), and the “stem” as “anything that an affix attaches to”, which “may be the base but may also be larger than the base”. However, in most later places in the textbook, including in the glossary, these terms are precisely reversed. Also early in the textbook, as well as in several other places, Punske uses the terms “lexicalist” and “lexical” interchangeably, to refer to theories of morphology that are non-syntax-based. However, in the morphology literature, these terms are not generally used interchangeably, with the term “lexical” sometimes used specifically to refer to morpheme-based theories (a usage originating in Stump 2001), an orthogonal dimension to whether a theory is lexicalist or not. A more specialized terminological confusion that we feel is worth mentioning, given our own research expertise, is found in Chapter Five, where a “pivot” is referred to as “a defined point in the base which is the target for reduplication and infixation” (p. 95); for example, the Uradhi infix under discussion in this chapter is described as having the distribution “ $\sigma_1$ -PIVOT- $\sigma_2$ ” (p. 96), thereby showing up at the juncture between the first and second syllables. This use of the term “pivot” is at odds with the literature, which instead defines the pivot as the phonological unit which an infixal element is positioned with respect to or (less commonly) which a reduplicant copies. Restated in this way, the Uradhi morpheme’s infixal pivot is the first syllable, and its reduplication pivot is the second syllable (or, equivalently here, the syllable following the reduplicant).

Three DM-specific issues which are mainly terminological also could use clearing up. First, the term “syntax” is sometimes used in the textbook to subsume the whole Y model, thus consistent with a statement like “in Distributed Morphology, syntax and morphology are the same” (p. 12, and expressed similarly elsewhere a number of times), while other times being used to refer *just* to the combinatorial and other operations that precede spellout in the Y model (p. 149, and elsewhere). The DM literature usually uses “syntax” in this latter way. Second, at the outset of Part Two of the textbook, a vocabulary item in DM is defined as “a morphological item and its bundle of associated features” (p. 110) and is equated with what was called a “morpheme” in Part One of the textbook. We think this is a missed opportunity to clarify that in DM, the classic morpheme is split into two parts, (i) an abstract, phonology-less element (a feature, set of features, or root) that is a terminal node in the syntax, referred to as an abstract morpheme in DM scholarship, and (ii) a *post*-syntactically available correspondence between a phonological exponent and a (set of) feature(s) and/or abstract root, referred to as a vocabulary item in DM scholarship. Finally, the way DM derivations are shown to proceed is at odds with the literature. Specifically, the textbook version of Vocabulary Insertion involves bottom-up insertion of exponents (in line with the literature) that considers only the immediate sisters in a subtree as the available context (not in line with the literature); this means that exponence has to be able to be delayed for some terminals, if the necessary context for choosing among vocabulary items is not contained in this immediate subtree (see, e.g., p. 153). This is, we think, an unnecessary complexification of the theory that is not pedagogically helpful.

Next we point out a few types of recurring pedagogical issues in the textbook. We’ll draw specific examples from Chapter Seven, as it’s such an important chapter in the textbook, and has the most significant amount of such issues. Some pedagogical stumbling blocks come from discussions and illustrations that are too brief. For example, head movement, which is taken to underlie all word formation, is illustrated with the adjective *blackened* (pp. 157-158). Deriving this word involves four instances of head movement and two Adj heads. The steps of head movement are shown in sequence in a diagram, with very little discussion about what is happening in the text itself. For a student who has never seen head movement before, the trees on their own are especially difficult to follow as they do not have arrows indicating movement, nor any notation indicating what has moved (e.g., a trace or strike-through). Other pedagogical stumbling blocks come from choices of exemplars that are not ideal for illustrating a point. For example, the sole exemplar of Fusion is English suppletive comparatives and superlatives, for which it is proposed that the root fuses with both the Adj head and the Comp head, forming a single insertion site. This is puzzling from the perspective of the persistence of *-er* in *better*, is at odds with influential literature in DM (Bobaljik 2012), and provides a potentially confusing (non-acknowledged) contrast with earlier Hiaki data (pp. 152-153), where it is proposed

that root suppletion should be dealt with through the mechanism of contextual allomorphy.

Finally, and this is largely a critique about the publisher, Wiley-Blackwell, the textbook has hundreds of typos and formatting problems. Some of these are due to particular linguistic conventions, like gloss alignment, which is incorrectly formatted even in the example meant to illustrate proper glossing (example (3) on p. 7). Like gloss alignment, most of the typos and formatting issues are innocuous, but still a significant number impede clarity, especially considering an audience of beginner-level students. For example, in derivations of reduplication in Tawala, an output that should be *hopuhopu* is consistently misrendered as *hopu* (see (22) and (23) on pp. 92-93). And, in many of the pedagogically useful text boxes (see discussion above), there are what seem to be copy-paste errors in the text inside the boxes. See, for example, the top diagram related to Polish pronouns on p. 115, with a text box that says “-i matches by [m] and [pl]” when it should say “-i blocked by [m] and [pl]”. Given the other types of issues we discuss above, students may struggle throughout the textbook with figuring out what is a typo, what is an analytical error, and what is a lack in their understanding.

Writing a textbook is a very time- and energy-consuming endeavor, and we applaud Punske for taking on the important work of writing a textbook specific to DM that builds up the analysis of morphology from the ground up. We hope that with this review, instructors have the information they need to decide whether and how to utilize this textbook in its current edition. We also hope that, in a second edition, this textbook can become the touchstone resource that it has the potential to be, finding a place within the canon of introductory, undergraduate-level, generative linguistics textbooks that exist for other subfields.

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